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US POLITICS · JUDICIARY · ISRAEL/MIDEAST · VATICAN · WORLD · LONG READS

THE BIG STORY

Trump calls off imminent strike on Iran after Tehran reportedly agrees to a compromise on the Strait of Hormuz, brokered by Qatar and Oman — even as Israeli strikes kill 18 in Gaza and Saudi Arabia's crown prince personally lobbies Trump toward de-escalation.

U.S. POLITICS

Senate strikes stopgap deal, punts shutdown fight past midterms

Senate appropriators agreed Monday to a bipartisan continuing resolution funding the government through December 11, buying roughly ten more weeks to finish the twelve FY2027 appropriations bills. The full Senate held a procedural vote Monday evening on the vehicle, H.R. 6500; if it passes, the House must approve identical text before it reaches the president's desk. Government funding otherwise lapses September 30.

WHY IT MATTERS

This punts the shutdown fight past the November midterms rather than resolving it — the same brinkmanship returns in a lame-duck December session, with a narrower and more exhausted majority doing the negotiating.

Senate Appropriations Committee / UPI · [appropriations.senate.gov](https://www.appropriations.senate.gov)

Blanche's AG nomination stalls as Cornyn, Tillis hold out

The Senate Judiciary Committee postponed its vote on Todd Blanche's nomination for attorney general after Sens. John Cornyn (R-TX) and Thom Tillis (R-NC) withheld support, demanding the Justice Department formally disavow a settlement in Trump's lawsuit against the IRS. Trump has floated pulling the nomination and leaving Blanche as acting AG until Cornyn and Tillis leave office in January — both are departing Congress, Cornyn after losing his primary to Ken Paxton.

ANALYTICAL READ

Retiring, primary-defeated Republicans are spending their last months in office settling a score with an administration that no longer needs their votes — a preview of how thin Trump's margin for institutional dissent has become.

The Hill / CBS News · thehill.com

SCOTUS & THE JUDICIARY

Trump asks Supreme Court to hear appeal of \$83.3 million defamation verdict

Trump has petitioned the Supreme Court to hear his appeal of the \$83.3 million E. Jean Carroll defamation verdict, with the justices expected to consider the petition in late summer.

WHY IT MATTERS

A grant would put the Court in the position of reviewing a jury verdict against a sitting president after a full trial and appellate review already upheld it.

SCOTUSblog · [scotusblog.com](https://www.scotusblog.com)

Trump signals he will ask Court to revive suit against Hillary Clinton

Separately, Trump says he will ask the Supreme Court to revive his RICO suit against Hillary Clinton, the DNC, and others over the Steele dossier, after a unanimous Eleventh

Circuit panel — including a judge Trump himself appointed — called the original suit frivolous and upheld nearly \$1 million in sanctions against Trump and his attorney.

ANALYTICAL READ

Two Republican-appointed appellate judges affirming sanctions is a strong signal about how this petition is likely to fare; the move looks more like a venue for political messaging than a serious cert bid.

SCOTUSblog · [scotusblog.com](https://www.scotusblog.com)

A parallel, quieter story: a growing bipartisan push to curb the Supreme Court's own power is gaining traction amid the Court's falling approval ratings, even as justices separately seek increased security funding from Congress amid a rise in threats.

SCOTUSblog · [scotusblog.com](https://www.scotusblog.com)

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

Trump calls off Iran strike after reported Hormuz compromise

Trump called off a planned large-scale strike on Iran after Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi reportedly agreed to a Qatar- and U.S.-brokered compromise on the Strait of Hormuz: ships would enter the Gulf via the Iranian-controlled side and exit via Oman's side. Oman is seeking guarantees the arrangement will hold against the IRGC, which Qatar is working to secure. Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman separately called Trump to press for de-escalation, warning that a wider war could pull Gulf energy infrastructure into the fighting.

ANALYTICAL READ

The report of Araghchi's concession comes from anonymous Israeli sources briefing Hebrew-language Channel 12 — that is positioning by parties with an interest in shaping the narrative before U.S. decision-makers, not a verified diplomatic fact. Israel's own working assumption, per its officials, is that it gets drawn into any U.S.-Iran war regardless of whether it is asked to join, which makes an independent Israeli decision to escalate — or to leak reports that scuttle de-escalation — strategically valuable to Jerusalem and costly to Washington.

The Times of Israel · [timesofisrael.com](https://www.timesofisrael.com)

Israel raises alert; U.S. Navy stretched defending both Israel and homeland

Israel raised its alert level over the weekend on the assessment that Trump was close to ordering renewed strikes on Iran, with the U.S. embassy in Israel and embassies across Jordan, Egypt, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and Iraq advising citizens to consider leaving. A Washington

Post report says U.S. European Command chief Gen. Alexus Grynkeiwich privately warned the Pentagon he lacks enough naval assets to keep defending both Israel and the U.S. homeland from missile threats simultaneously.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR THE US

This is a direct U.S.-Israel interest divergence, on the record from a U.S. combatant commander: American destroyers are stretched between defending the homeland and defending Israel — a tradeoff Washington should be making explicitly, not by default.

The Jerusalem Post · [jpost.com](https://www.jpost.com)

Israeli strikes kill 18 in Gaza as minister denies any halt agreement

Israeli strikes killed at least 18 people in Gaza on Sunday, including two children, the heaviest single-day toll in weeks, even as Trump was publicly announcing a breakthrough toward implementing last year's ceasefire. An Israeli minister said there is no deal to halt the attacks; the military said one strike targeted two Hamas Nukhba-force commanders in Deir al-Balah.

ANALYTICAL READ

The standard justification here is a targeted counterterrorism strike, but an eighteen-person, two-child death toll delivered the same weekend Washington is publicly claiming ceasefire progress is worth scrutinizing on its own terms — it suggests Israeli military operations are proceeding on a timeline set in Jerusalem, not Washington, regardless of what the White House says about the state of diplomacy.

NBC News · [nbcnews.com](https://www.nbcnews.com)

ITALY, ROME & THE VATICAN

Pope Leo XIV appeals for Ceuta amid deadly migration crisis

Following his August 2 Angelus in St. Peter's Square, Pope Leo XIV addressed the migration emergency in Ceuta, the Spanish enclave bordering Morocco, where tens of thousands have attempted to cross and at least 67 people have died in the attempt. Speaking in Spanish, he said: "I follow with concern the alarming situation in Ceuta, asking God, through the intercession of Our Lady of Africa, that solutions of peace, stability, and justice may be found." He went on to pray "that wars may cease throughout the world and that diplomatic solutions to conflicts may be found," naming children, the elderly, and the sick among war's most defenseless victims. He also marked the Pardon of Assisi, the plenary indulgence tracing to a 1216 vision in which St. Francis asked Christ for a full remission of sins for all who entered the Porziuncola chapel; it is available August 1–2 to anyone who makes sacramental confession, receives the Eucharist, and prays at a parish or Franciscan church.

Vatican News · [vaticannews.va](https://www.vaticannews.va)

Pope back from Castel Gandolfo, hints at U.S. trip

The Pope returned to the Vatican this week after his summer stay at Castel Gandolfo and is set to travel briefly to Rimini for the 47th Meeting for Friendship among Peoples, with an Assumption Day Mass (August 15) planned at a Castel Gandolfo parish. He has also hinted, in comments to NBC News, at a forthcoming trip to the United States.

WHY IT MATTERS

A sitting pope confirming a U.S. visit, even informally, is a significant signal for Catholic institutions and dioceses now beginning logistical planning.

Vatican News / NBC News · [vaticannews.va](https://www.vaticannews.va)

WORLD NEWS

Hormuz standoff has already rattled global energy markets

The Strait of Hormuz standoff has already disrupted the movement of Middle Eastern oil and shaken global markets; the tentative Araghchi-brokered compromise on transit lanes, if it holds, would be the first concrete de-escalation step since the current Iran-U.S. confrontation began in February.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR THE US

Sustained uncertainty in the Strait keeps upward pressure on global energy prices regardless of whether the U.S. or Israel ultimately strikes Iran again.

Times of Israel / JPost · [timesofisrael.com](https://www.timesofisrael.com)

RESEARCH & LONG READS

The American right's widening schism

Axios's Jim VandeHei and Mike Allen argue American politics is imploding along several fault lines at once: MAGA is splitting between Trump loyalists and self-described "America First" purists after Tucker Carlson and Marjorie Taylor Greene both renounced the GOP over the Iran war; Democrats face their own insurgent-socialist "Tea Party" moment; and support for Israel is collapsing across both parties' younger cohorts (Pew found 60 percent of Americans now view Israel unfavorably, including 57 percent of Republicans under 50). The piece ties directly to today's Cornyn-Tillis-Blanche standoff: the same establishment-versus-populist fracture, playing out in miniature inside the Senate GOP.

Axios ("Behind the Curtain") · [axios.com/2026/06/25/trump-america-politics-maga-socialism-israel](https://www.axios.com/2026/06/25/trump-america-politics-maga-socialism-israel)

Catholic apologetics, defended on its own terms

Theologian Glenn B. Siniscalchi, writing in Notre Dame's Church Life Journal, argues that reasoned defense of Catholic doctrine is a biblical mandate (1 Peter 3:15, Jude 3), not a relic of pre-Vatican-II fundamentalism as critics like Myron Penner allege. He marshals Vatican II documents (Dei Verbum, Lumen Gentium), the conversions of C.S. Lewis, Antony Flew, and Frank Morison, and Cardinal Avery Dulles's "rebirth of apologetics" thesis to argue that faith without reason collapses into fideism, while charity and holiness are themselves forms of apologetic argument, not substitutes for it.

Church Life Journal, Univ. of Notre Dame · churchlifejournal.nd.edu/articles/catholic-apologetics-and-the-new-evangelization